Notes from Underground to 1984

by way of We and Brave New World — the outlier ignored → diagnosed → removed → hunted, broken, and rebuilt

Class 2 of *Tales of Defiance to Mind Control in the Modern Age*

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Contents

Road Map . . . 1
Table of Context . . . 1
Notes from Underground (1864): The Outlier Ignored . . . 2
Stepping Stones: Outlier Diagnosed → Outlier Removed . . . 3
1984: From Self-Watching to Big Brother Watching . . . 3
1984: Newspeak, Controlling the Story . . . 3
Bruner's Terms, Applied to Winston . . . 4
Fromm's Afterword: Can a Boot Stamp on a Human Face Forever? . . . 4
The Through-Line: Control Dressed as Care . . . 4
Questions for the Room . . . 4
What Comes Next: *The Matrix* . . . 4

Road Map

- **Table of Context:** four books, four authors, four fates
- **Where we left off:** the Underground Man, an outlier no one bothers to control
- **Two stepping stones:** Zamyatin's *We* and Huxley's *Brave New World*
- **1984 through two lenses:** Disciplinary Surveillance and Narrative Analysis (from the Preface reading)
- **Fromm's Afterword:** can the longing for freedom be stamped out?

Table of Context

Book	Author	Written[1]	Country	Influences	System	Defiance	Treatment
Notes from Underground	Fyodor Dostoevsky	1863–64	Russia	Chernyshevsky's *What Is to Be Done?*, Russian nihilism, Siberian prison and exile	Rational egoism	Spite	Ignored

Book	Author	Written[1]	Country	Influences	System	Defiance	Treatment
We	Yevgeny Zamyatin	1920–21	Russia	Bolshevik turned Soviet dissident; Scientific Management (Taylorism); H. G. Wells	Clockwork efficiency	A soul	Cured
Brave New World	Aldous Huxley	1931	England	WWI, pacifism, utopian visions, behavioral psychology, eugenics, consumerism	Hedonism	Questioning	Removed
1984	George Orwell	1944–48	England	Burma, Spanish Civil War, WWII, fascism, communism, Zamyatin's *We*, tuberculosis	State ownership, even of thought	Longing	Crushed

Notes from Underground (1864): The Outlier Ignored

Human Outlier Analysis

- **No room for him**
  - He warns that reason would make men into piano keys
    - $2 + 2 = 4$, forced on us from outside
  - He is an outlier society has no room for
    - His schoolmates ignore him or laugh at him
- **Trapped in himself**
  - He watches and persecutes himself
    - "Acute consciousness" audits every gesture[2]
  - His defiance — spite, perversity — is entirely private
  - He argues against rational egoism…
    - …but can't escape the cave of his own ego
    - He cannot accept love (Liza)

[1] Dates are when each book was written. Publication: 1864; 1924 (in English; 1927 in Russian); 1932; 1949.
[2] Check the "acute consciousness" passage against the Larry Cedar performance transcript.

Stepping Stones: Outlier Diagnosed → Outlier Removed

Fromm calls *We*, *Brave New World*, and *1984* a trilogy of "negative Utopias."[3]

- **Zamyatin's *We*** (written 1920–21; English 1924)
  - A city of glass: the rational utopia Dostoevsky mocked[4]
  - D-503: mathematician, model citizen
  - Glass apartments; citizens inform as a civic duty
  - He grows a "soul" — $2 + 2 = 4$ isn't all there is
  - Treated as an illness; the Great Operation removes imagination
- **Huxley's *Brave New World*** (1932)
  - Conditioning installs the watcher before birth
  - A dystopia of pleasure: free sex and soma
  - Bernard and Helmholtz push at the cracks — sent to islands
  - John the Savage claims "the right to be unhappy" — the Underground Man's argument, reborn
- **Fromm's contrast:** *We* and *1984* rule by terror plus manipulation; *Brave New World* by mass suggestion, with no need for terror.

1984: From Self-Watching to Big Brother Watching

Disciplinary Surveillance

- **Outward**
  - Telescreens, Thought Police, children who inform
  - Big Brother: always watching, listening, controlling
  - The Party cannot tolerate a single Underground Man
- **Back inward (the Panopticon)**[5]
  - Never knowing when you're watched, you watch yourself
  - Winston polices his face, sleep-talk, handwriting
  - By the end, his own monitor — on the Party's behalf
- **Staged shunning:** Goldstein is a manufactured outlier; the Two Minutes Hate is society's rejection performed as daily ritual.
- **The image:** the Underground Man's inner critic was his own — the Party takes it over.

Clips: 1:12:18 — Telescreen reveal: "We are the dead" · 0:27:19 — "War is peace…" (the Party slogans)

1984: Newspeak, Controlling the Story

Narrative Analysis

- **Three note-writers**
  - The Underground Man writes to "gentlemen" who may not exist
  - D-503 writes to unknown readers on other planets
  - Winston writes his diary to the future
  - Each journal is where the self survives — and each state wants it closed
- **Newspeak makes the diary impossible**
  - Shrink the vocabulary until disloyal thoughts can't be formed
  - The Underground Man resists by never stopping talking; Orwell imagines a regime that removes the words
- **The 2 + 2 inversion**[6]
  - Dostoevsky: defy $2 \times 2 = 4$ — reason is the tyrant
  - Orwell: cling to $2 + 2 = 4$ — reality is under attack

[3] Erich Fromm, Afterword to the 1961 Signet edition of *1984*. Huxley himself used the term "negative utopia."

[4] The Cedar transcript does not include Dostoevsky's Crystal Palace passage. In one line: the Underground Man ridicules a glass-and-iron palace of perfect reason, and Zamyatin builds a whole city on that model.

[5] Foucault, *Discipline and Punish* (1975), "Panopticism" — the lens named in the course Preface for *1984*.

[6] Check that the $2 \times 2 = 4$ passage is in the Cedar transcript; if not, use the inversion as a facilitator's aside.

Clips: 0:06:16 — "Think in Newspeak…" · 0:10:31 — Winston's diary: "From a dead man, greetings"

Bruner's Terms, Applied to Winston

Narrative Analysis — terms from the Preface reading questions[7]

- **Canonical script:** the Party's version of how to think, act, and remember
- **Breach:** the first word Winston writes in the diary
- **Intentional states:** his private thoughts — the one place the telescreen can't see, until Room 101
- **Narrative vs. systemic truth:** Winston's memory against the Ministry of Truth and the memory hole
- **Accrual:** can private defiance add up to a movement? Julia, the Brotherhood, Goldstein's book — and why none of it accrues

Clips: 0:00:01 — "Who controls the past controls the future…" · 1:24:43 — "Reality is in the human mind…"

Fromm's Afterword: Can a Boot Stamp on a Human Face Forever?

- **Central question:** can human nature be changed so we forget our longing for freedom, dignity, and love?
- **Severity proves strength:** a brain operation (*We*), drugs and breeding (*Brave New World*), unlimited torture (*1984*) — the cure shows how strong the striving is
- **The minority of one:** when truth is whatever the Party says, a minority of one must believe he is insane — the outlier lens returns
- **Doublethink is not just "them":** Fromm insists *1984* "means us, too"
- **Fromm's hope:** a fully dehumanized world would be a world of madmen — not a viable one

Clips: 1:29:32 — O'Brien on power · 1:30:53 — Boot on the face · 1:37:19 — Room 101

The Through-Line: Control Dressed as Care

- **No controller:** the Underground Man has no one who pretends to love him
- **Happiness for freedom:** Zamyatin's Benefactor and Huxley's Mustapha Mond make the trade
- **Caring face, no promise:** "Big Brother" is family language; O'Brien, tender in Room 101, says he is curing Winston
- **Fromm:** O'Brien is Dostoevsky's Grand Inquisitor — except the Party no longer even pretends to make people happy

Clip: 0:39:00 — "…the place where there is no darkness"

Questions for the Room

1. The Underground Man was ignored; Winston is watched every minute. Which is lonelier?
2. Is secret writing to an unknown reader a kind of freedom? What happens when the words are taken away?
3. Can a society force 2 + 2 to equal 4, or 5 — or make it not matter at all?
4. Are you an outlier? Would you rather be ignored, diagnosed, removed, or hunted, broken, and rebuilt?
5. *From Fromm:* do severe methods prove the strength of what they suppress — or make the defiant stronger?
6. *From the homework:* is history written by the victors? Is truth written by those in power?

What Comes Next: *The Matrix*

- **Blue pill:** unknowingly accept a virtual reality

[7] Jerome Bruner, "The Narrative Construction of Reality," *Critical Inquiry* 18:1 (1991).

- **Red pill:** see the truth — even $2 + 2 = 4$ is just code underneath: $10 + 10 = 100$ in binary
- The controller changes again: the Architect doesn't watch you or break you — he builds the world you live in.